ANNUAL MEMBERS:
It's Time to Renew!
See Page 9

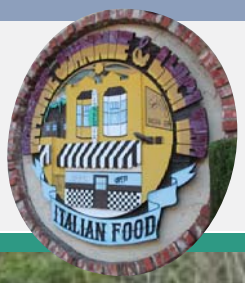
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
Volume XII Issue 1 Winter 2022



Page 4
Stevens Creek Tails! Learn more about the focus of our winter event.



Page 7
Street Talk: Revisited: The family behind Ehrhorn Avenue in Old Mountain View.

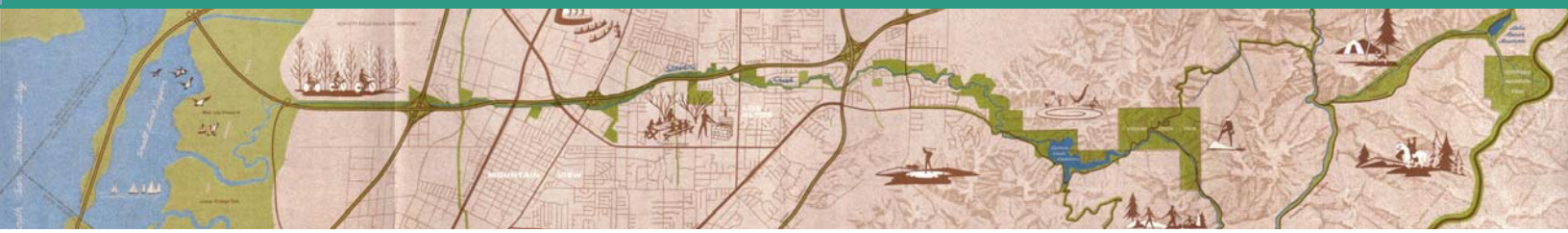


Page 8
History Happening Now: NASA telescope launches, goodbye FJ&L, and familiar faces at City Hall.



A Path to History

THE STORY OF STEVENS CREEK



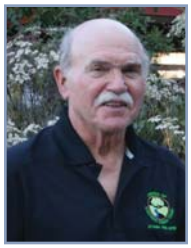
Our Winter 2022 Event

Join us on Sunday, February 20 for our winter meeting where we will focus on the history of one of Mountain View's most prominent natural features, Stevens Creek!

Over the course of the pandemic, many have discovered or rediscovered the many joys and health benefits of spending time outdoors in nature. The importance of easy access to outdoor spaces where we can walk, bike, or just sit on a bench has perhaps never been more apparent in our lifetimes.

In Mountain View, we are fortunate to have Stevens Creek and its eponymous trail winding its way through our city, providing an easy way for people to quickly access a bit of nature in the midst of Silicon Valley. The history of Stevens Creek, and how its trail and park chain came into being, will be the focus our next event. We hope you'll join us for what is sure to be a fascinating talk!

REGISTER ONLINE: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com



GREG UNANGST

Our Guest Speaker

Greg Unangst is a West Point graduate. He spent 10 years on active duty and 18 years in the Reserves, ultimately retiring as a lieutenant colonel. In addition to his BS in general engineering from West Point, Greg earned an MS in electrical engineering and an MBA, both from the University of Pennsylvania, and a masters in public policy from NYU. Greg worked in the aerospace/satellite industry for 33 years at Ford Aerospace, Loral, and Lockheed-Martin until his retirement in 2011. Since retiring, Greg joined the Board of Friends of Stevens Creek Trail and was recently elected president. He is also the Co-Chairman of the Restoration Advisory Board (RAB), Moffett Federal Field, and is a County Roads Commissioner. Greg has been married to Pamela Baird for 28 years and has resided in Mountain View since 1998.

Sunday, February 20, 2022 ● 1:00 to 3:00 p.m. ● Free Zoom Webinar

MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

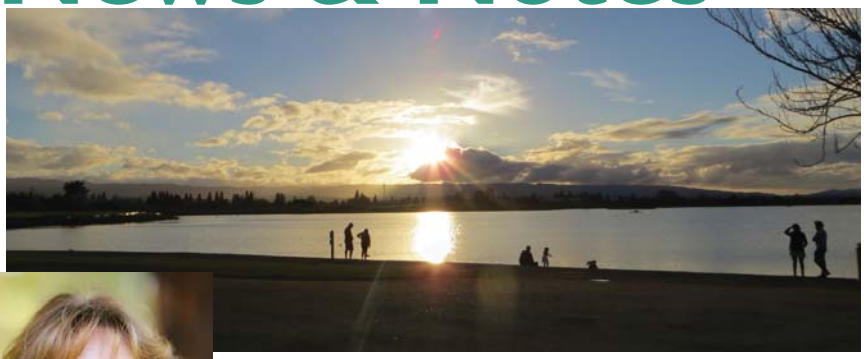
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News & Notes





Pamela Baird

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

Well, here we are again. As I write this the Omicron variant is surging. The number of new COVID cases in the US is at an all-time level—more than any other time of the pandemic. A local school district is asking parents to volunteer because of staff shortages. Testing opportunities are hard to find. Stanford delayed in person classes by three weeks. When will this end?

Diseases have changed the course of history in many areas of the world. Repeated waves of bubonic plague that swept Europe from 1300–1700 killed 20–30% of the population and is thought to have upended civic, social, and church organizations. The many diseases that Europeans brought to the New World killed up to 90% of the native populations, destroying many civilizations.

In 1793, Philadelphia suffered a cholera epidemic that killed 10% of its population. In the 1800s, over 20 outbreaks of yellow fever occurred in the American South. In 1777, George Washington ordered the inoculation of the troops against smallpox, a devastating disease that was rapidly spreading among them.

But disease can affect people, families, and small communities as well. The namesake of our February 20 public meeting, Elisha Stephens, was a leader in the successful Murphy-Stephens wagon train crossing of the Sierras. The extended Murphy family decided to leave Missouri because of an outbreak of malaria, which killed two family members.

As many communicable diseases have been eradicated by better cleanliness, improved public water and sewage systems, and vaccines, many of us have no experience with people or families that have seen the effects of communicable diseases. My mother contracted polio when I was a baby. She spent six months in hospitals. Some of the time she was in an iron lung, which helped her breathe. Polio left her with profound disabilities that made every day a struggle.

Two brothers of my husband's father died of typhus on the same day when they were little boys in coal country Pennsylvania. The sister of my uncle (by marriage) died at the age of 18 from tuberculosis in rural Nebraska. All of these diseases can or have been prevented or eliminated by modern medicine.

The many lives that have been lost (or changed) remind us how precious every life is to each family and community. Let us be thankful that science has been able to protect us, our families, communities, and country against the devastation of disease.

—Pamela

DAR Early Settlers Project

By Martha Wallace
Special Contributor

In September 2020, the Los Altos Chapter of the Daughters of the American Revolution (DAR) embarked on a one-year project to learn about the life and history of early settlers in the Los Altos/Mountain View area. So often we learn only about the famous people; this project helped us learn about people for whom our streets, schools, and local landmarks are named: some famous and some not so well-known.

We concentrated on people who lived in or were active in early Los Altos, Mountain View, and Los Altos Hills before 1900 to help us understand the pioneering and entrepreneurial spirit that contributed to the commercial and civic evolution of the early San Francisco Bay Area.

Due to the pandemic, the project was designed to be completed while quarantining and staying at home, using information we could find at home and online: maps, genealogy resources, internet articles, newspapers, books, and more. Participants often chose to investigate the pre-1900 owner of the property where they now live, or a street or school named for a property owner.

The results were reported in one-sheet profiles created for each settler. A compilation of these profiles was assembled and published in PDF format in September 2021. That PDF with clickable links is available on request at: losaltosdar@gmail.com.

Printed copies should soon be available at the Los Altos Library, the Mountain View Public Library, the Santa Clara City Library, and the Los Altos History Museum.

Financial Report

By Emily Ramos
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 10/6/2021: $22,307.12
Income: $1,240.91
Expenses: $2,320.00
Checking Account Balance as of 1/18/2022: $21,228.03

Certificates of Deposit Balance: $60,519.62

you needed a copy editor.

Cynthia Hanson
Editorial Consultant & Copy Editor

Whether you're updating your resume or writing the world's next great novel, Cynthia Hanson is available to help make sure your writing is clear and typo-free. As the MVHA's volunteer copy editor, she's helped make this newsletter shine and is available to hire for other projects.

Contact Cynthia today:
cynthialynnhanson@gmail.com

Finding Your Family History

By Robert Cox
MVHA Vice President

Many regular TV watchers have seen the commercials for Ancestry.com, which invite you to buy a subscription to their service or take a DNA test to discover more about your family history. While I agree that doing this is one of the best ways to discover your family's past, there are also several key free alternatives. If you are just beginning your family history research and you have more time than money, I recommend looking into them first.

My #1 choice for free family history information is Family Search, which is run by the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints (Mormon). They maintain online, searchable historic records as well as a worldwide family tree with entries for 1.3 billion people, making it the world's largest. Use of the records is open to anyone. Their historical records are primarily from the United States, Canada, and the United Kingdom, but they also have records from some other European countries. Their website is www.familysearch.org.

My #2 choice is Find-A-Grave website. It is an online database of cemetery records, primarily in the United States and Canada. The website was started in 1995 by Jim Tipton, to support his hobby of visiting the gravesites of famous people but has grown beyond that to include an almost complete inventory of gravesites in the USA and Canada. Because the website allows gravesites of immediate relatives to be linked to one another, it is often possible to follow a family's history many generations using the links. Check it out at www.findagrave.com.

My #3 choice is Wikitree, another worldwide family tree, started by Chris Whitten in 2008. Each person in the Wikitree has his or her own profile page, which is managed by a profile owner, who can be contacted by email. The profile owners are volunteer genealogists, each of whom has signed the Wikitree honor code. Wikitree genealogists collaborate to grow their worldwide family tree, and volunteer "arborists" work to merge duplicate entries. There are currently 27 million profiles in the Wikitree, mostly from the United States. I personally have contributed to almost 50,000 profiles on Wikitree. Their website is www.wikitree.com.

In my next column, I'll talk about DNA testing.



Former Mountain View Mayor John McAlister



Mtn. View Family History Fun Fact!
Former Mountain View Mayor John McAlister's seventh great-grandfather was also named John McAlister. He immigrated from Inverness, Scotland, to colonial Virginia in the late 1600s.

Special Feature
Stevens Creek Tails

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

From Wild to Tamed

From its start on the west side of Black Mountain to where it enters the bay, Stevens Creek covers over 20 miles of varied terrain and uses. Its early visitors were the local Ohlone Indians who fished, ate berries, and hunted game near the creek. What the Ohlone called the creek is unknown.

Four-hundred acres of land around the upper portion of the creek were purchased in 1924 to become the first county park in Santa Clara County. In 1935, a dam was built by the Santa Clara Valley Water Conservation District across the upper creek to meet the growing demand for aquifer replenishment. Today, a wide variety of activities are available around the dam and the 1,077-acre expanded park. These include hiking, bird watching, picnicking, fishing, and bicycling.

Flood control measures were built on lower portions of the creek in the 1940s–1950s. Areas where the concrete channel was constructed changed the appearance and use of the creek. But large portions of the creek were still wild enough that Santa Clara County considered these unaltered areas as a series of possible parks and parkways along the creek in 1961.

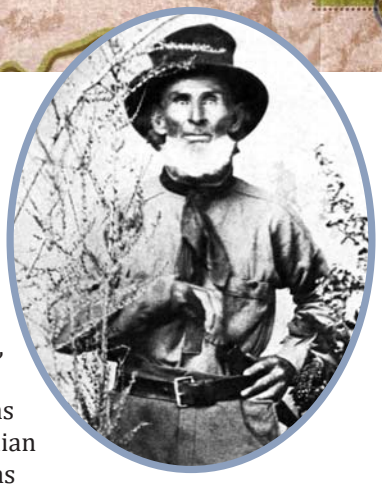
Today the creek is one of the most natural in the San Francisco Bay area, even in the most heavily populated areas. It flows through Cupertino, Los Altos, Sunnyvale, and Mountain View where it enters the Bay between Mountain View and Moffett Field.

The Creek's Friends

The Friends of Stevens Creek Trail was the brainchild of Rhonda Scherber Farrar. As a Mountain View Environmental Planning Commissioner, she was surprised to learn about 40 acres of public land along the creek in Mountain View that had been envisioned as part of a park trail more than 30 years earlier. In Silicon Valley fashion, she wrote a business plan for a community organization that would aid the cities and other jurisdictions along the trail to get it built. She recruited prominent members of the community to form the Friends as a 501(c)(3) organization in 1993. The Friends have been working diligently ever since to promote the value that the Stevens Creek Trail brings to the area and supporting local government efforts to get a trail built from the San Francisco Bay to the Santa Cruz Mountain Ridge. Friends has successfully encouraged the expansion of the trail in Mountain View and construction of the trail in portions of Cupertino. More efforts are planned for the future.



Who was "Steven"?



Who is the man for which Stevens Creek is named? Not much is known about his early life, other than Elisha Stephens was born in South Carolina and moved to Georgia at a young age. Evidently, he was in the fur trade, which is probably why he was in Council Bluffs, Iowa, and later was employed by the Potawatomi Indian sub-agency as a blacksmith. It was from there that he embarked on a dangerous and exhausting seven-month odyssey to Alta California. In 1844, at the age of 40, he joined a wagon train heading west and was soon selected captain of the 11 ox-drawn wagon party of 50 people, later known as the "Stephens-Townsend-Murphy Party." The route the group followed for the first 1,600 miles was mostly along the established Oregon Trail.

But it was the last 400 miles that was truly a ground-breaking endeavor. Not knowing the exact route to Alta California, the party encountered a Paiute Indian who told them there was a river quite a distance to the west that may lead them to the Sierra Nevada. The group followed the information, which did lead them to the Sierras. The route had never been traversed by a wagon train, but by sheer force of effort, a portion of the group successfully went over the pass in two-foot-deep snow. The details are too complicated to list here.

After entering California, Stephens participated in the lead-up to the Bear Flag Revolt—the rebellion of American settlers against the Mexican rule of Alta California. From 1846–1848, Stephens was an ordnance blacksmith in San Diego during the Mexican-American War.

In the 1850s, Stephens purchased a total of 330 acres of land along a creek named *Arroyo San José de Cupertino*, later known as "Cupertino Creek." The creek was eventually named after Stephens (although misspelled) along with a road that led to his property, Stevens Creek Road. Stephens named his land Blackberry Farm and there he grew grapes and blackberries, fished, and hunted. He stayed there until 1864 when he left because the area was getting "too durn civilized."

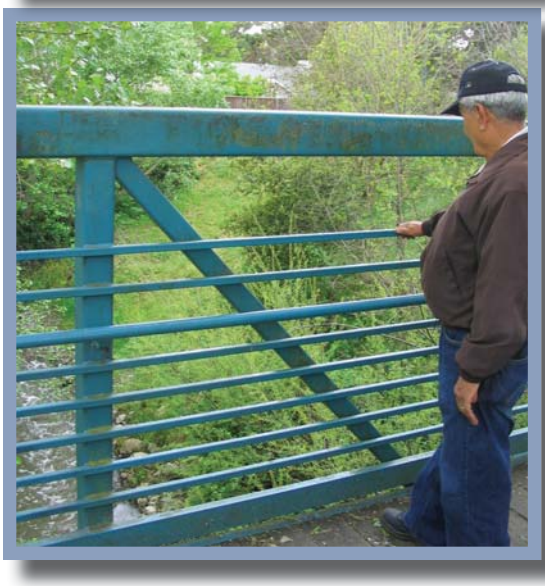
Stephens then moved to the Bakersfield area where he lived until his passing in 1887. Several historic markers in the Sierras note this groundbreaking crossing of the Sierras. In addition, a mountain near Donner Lake is named for him.

Join us on Sunday, February 20 at our quarterly meeting where we'll share more information about Elisha Stephens, Stevens Creek, and the trail!

Stevens Creek
Mtn. View Memories

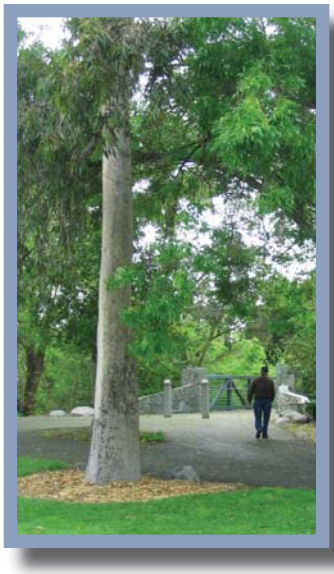
By Nicholas Perry
Past President





While looking for images of Stevens Creek to include in this newsletter, I rediscovered a whole series of pictures I hadn't seen in years buried in one of my external hard drives. The photos were taken during an afternoon exploring Stevens Creek with my grandpa, Simon Sias, nearly 17 years ago, back in March 2005. At the time, I was taking a landscape architecture class focused on creek restoration in Mediterranean climates. When I needed to select a local creek as a case study for my term project, I chose the creek I knew the best: Stevens Creek.

I'd forgotten my grandpa decided to accompany me as I ventured out along the Stevens Creek Trail to photograph it for my project. The two of us enjoyed going on random day trips together, exploring interesting spots around the Santa Clara Valley, especially places where the landscape reminded him of what our area used to look like when he first arrived here as a child during the Great Depression. The photos on this page are from that 2005 walk along the creek together; just a few years before my grandpa passed away. It's just one of many happy memories along the banks of Stevens Creek.



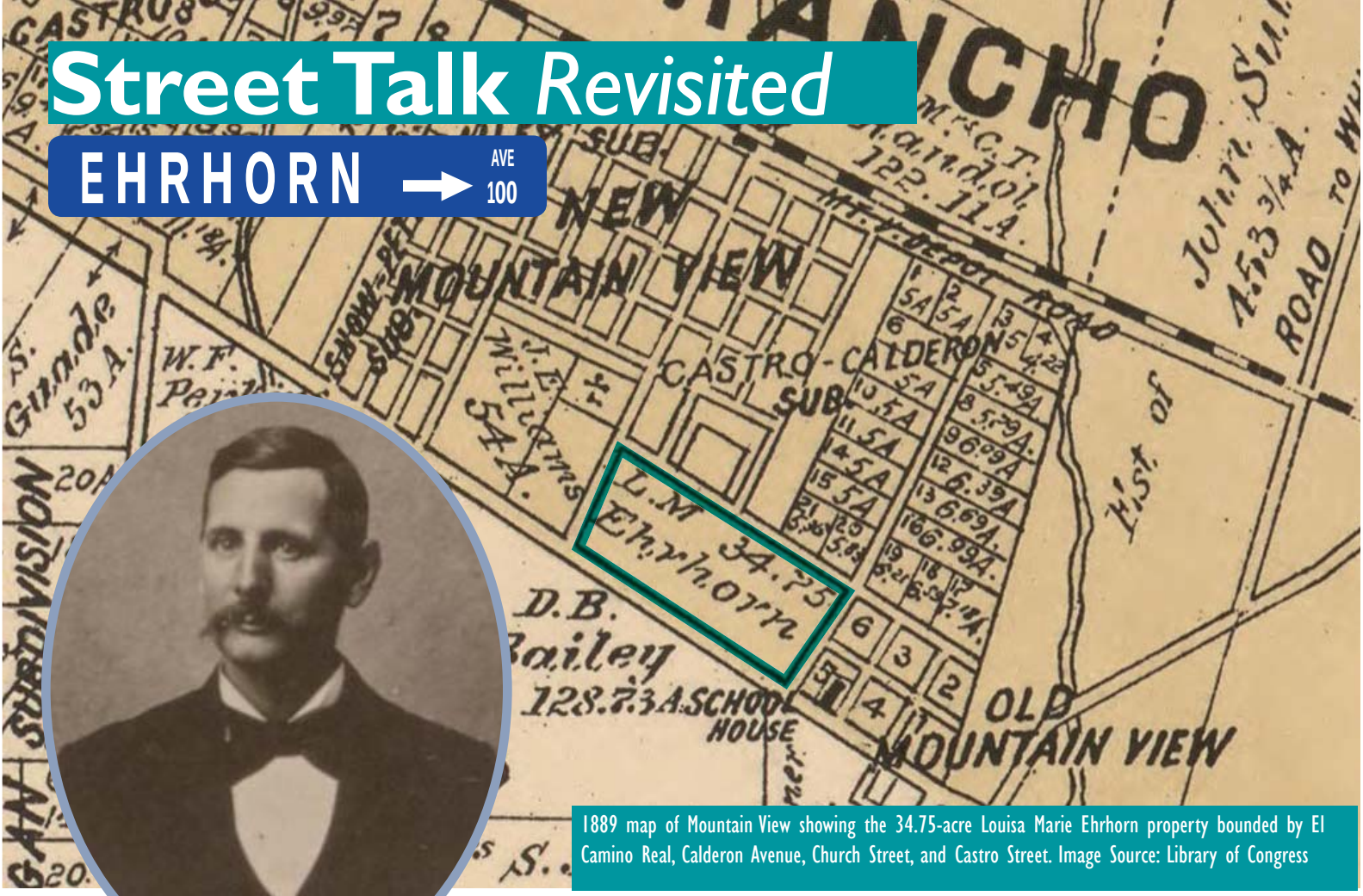
My earliest memories of Stevens Creek are rainy day drives up the winding roads around the reservoir and up Stevens Canyon, admiring the gushing creek and spotting the small waterfalls that emerged after a good storm. This was especially exciting in the years after the big 1986–1992 drought finally ended.

My middle school and high school years were the trailblazing years for Mountain View's stretch of the Stevens Creek Trail. Every few years a new segment of the trail opened, offering new places to explore by foot or bike. It was especially exciting once "Reach 3" opened in 1999, with its big blue bridge over Central Expressway. Suddenly, it was easy and safe to bike from my home in the Shoreline West neighborhood all the way to the open waters of the San Francisco Bay, a ride I've enjoyed many times over the years.

One of my favorite memories is walking the trail after watching the Independence Day fireworks at Shoreline Amphitheater. My family, as well as many others, decided walking home along the trail would be more enjoyable than sitting in post-fireworks traffic. I remember the sounds of laughter, crickets, and frogs, with flashlights and the moon lighting our way on that warm summer evening.

Do you have special memories of Mountain View's creeks? Share them with us by emailing: info@mountainviewhistorical.org.

Street Talk *Revisited*



1889 map of Mountain View showing the 34.75-acre Louisa Marie Ehrhorn property bounded by El Camino Real, Calderon Avenue, Church Street, and Castro Street. Image Source: Library of Congress



Adolph Ehrhorn c. 1897

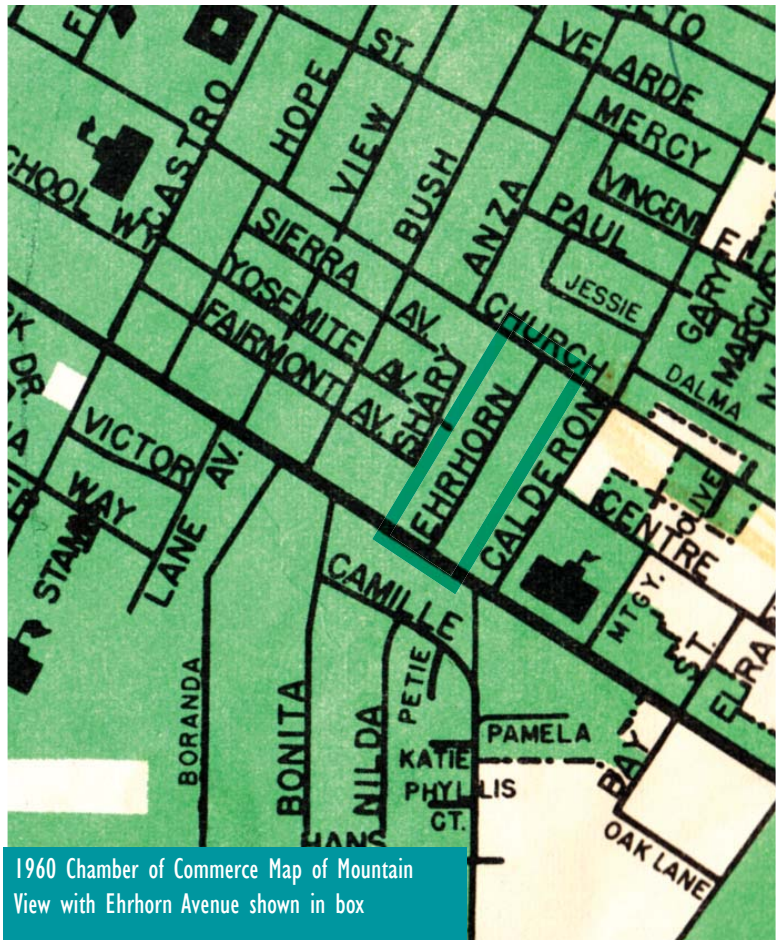
Editor's Note: The newsletter will be re-running a column that used to appear on a regular basis. Written by Barbara Kinchen, our longtime Historical Data Chair, who researched the names assigned to streets throughout the city. This column was originally published in our Spring 2011 newsletter.

In 1883, Mrs. Louisa Marie Ehrhorn of San Francisco bought property in Mountain View. Over 30 acres were bounded by Castro Street, Church Street, Calderon Avenue, and El Camino Real. The land was soon planted with fruit trees.

Mrs. Ehrhorn was a widow with a large family. She died in Mountain View in 1903. Her son, Adolph William Ehrhorn (1869–1947), lived on the orchard property until 1918 when he moved his family to Alviso Road, north of the railroad.

Sales and development of the El Camino property eventually resulted in three subdivisions: Nelson Manor on the west, Ehrhorn Tract on the east, and the large center portion was the Glumaz Subdivision.

Hope, View, and Bush Streets, were extended from Church Street to El Camino. In 1923, a new street, Ehrhorn Avenue, was laid out in the Ehrhorn Tract. At the time lots along Ehrhorn Avenue and Calderon were selling for $8 (equivalent to about $130 in 2022 dollars) "per front foot" (the lots were about 150 feet deep). Terms were 15% cash down and 36 monthly payments at 8% interest.



1960 Chamber of Commerce Map of Mountain View with Ehrhorn Avenue shown in box

Fall 2021 Snapshots



MVHA President Pamela Baird welcomes her walking tour group.

Exploring Downtown Mtn. View

On Sunday, November 7, 2021, the Mountain View Historical Association hosted guided walking tours of Downtown Mountain View. Tours were led by members of the MVHA Board of Directors who shared Downtown Mountain View's 150+-year evolution by telling the stories of historic sites and buildings on and around Castro Street.

A big THANK YOU to our tour guides and to everyone who joined us. Registration for all six tours filled up before the event and we know many who would have liked to attend were unable to. But good news! Due to the success of the event, our Board has decided to move forward with plans to turn the Downtown walking tours into a recurring program and, if weather allows, we will offer tours again starting on Sunday, February 27.

Interested in joining our February 27 walking tours? Details and registration info here: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com
Tours are free for MVHA Members; $15 suggested donation for non-members.



Above: Our friendly Treasurer Emily Ramos welcomes walking tour guests at Centennial Plaza.



The walking tour group led by MVHA Membership Chair IdaRose Sylvester got a special surprise bonus tour of the interior of the Mountain View Theater building (left) at 228 Castro Street, now home to the Monte Carlo nightclub.





MVHA Vice President Robert Cox (left) greets his tour group.



A tour group cross Evelyn Avenue and begins making their way down Castro Street.

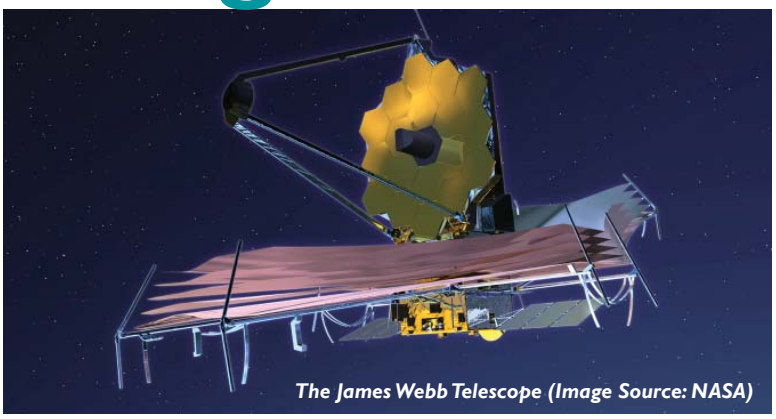
History Happening Now

Ames contributes to NASA's James Webb Space Telescope

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

Once again, NASA Ames has made significant contributions to the exploration of outer space. Early mission concepts, technology development, and modeling of the James Webb Space Telescope were all developed or enhanced by the scientists located on the Moffett Field campus. Ames researchers will also lead and contribute to the mission's science investigations.

Launched on December 25, the telescope is named after James E. Webb, the American government official who was the administrator of NASA from 1961 to 1968 and played an integral role in the Apollo program. The Webb telescope will peer more than 13.5 billion years back into cosmic history to explore the earliest galaxies and could transform our understanding of the universe.



The James Webb Telescope (Image Source: NASA)

The telescope will also study the atmospheres of planets orbiting other stars and observe moons, planets, comets, and other objects within our own solar system. All of Webb's onboard science instruments benefit from the contributions made by scientists at Ames. To learn more about the complicated achievements in the design and objectives of the James Webb Space Telescope, visit www.nasa.gov/feature/ames/webb.

FJ&L before in May 2021



FJ&L during demolition Jan. 4 2022



Photo Courtesy Kevin Bury

Arrivederci, for now, FJ&L

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

A longtime Mountain View landmark met the wrecking ball recently. Built in the 1920s, the two-story building at 939 El Camino Real was allegedly home to a Prohibition-era speakeasy, a coffeeshop, and then a pharmacy run by the Mantelli family. In 1947, Rocky D'Augustino rented the pharmacy and opened perhaps the first pizza parlor between San Francisco and Los Angeles. In 1956, brothers Frankie and Johnnie D'Ambrosio, along with their WWII buddy Luigi, bought the pizza parlor and Frankie, Johnnie, and Luigi Too! was born. Over the next 65 years, the pizza parlor grew and the D'Ambrosio family opened additional Italian restaurants. The D'Ambrosios plan on reopening the Mountain View location in 2023 as a counter service restaurant on the ground floor of a new three-story building being constructed on the site. The two floors above will become a senior memory care home. In the meantime, fans of FJ&L can get a taste of this classic Mountain View establishment at the D'Ambrosios' other restaurants: Giorgio's in San Jose, Milpitas, and a new location coming to Downtown Morgan Hill this spring.



New Mayor and Vice Mayor of Mountain View

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

On January 11, the City Council voted unanimously to appoint Lucas Ramirez as mayor and Alison Hicks as vice mayor of Mountain View. The meeting also served as an opportunity to thank outgoing Mayor Ellen Kamei. Both Mayor Ramirez and Vice Mayor Hicks are long-time supporters of the MVHA; Mayor Ramirez is a Life Member of the MVHA and Vice Mayor Hicks volunteered as one of our Directors-at-Large in 2017–18. Congratulations to Mayor Ramirez and Vice Mayor Hicks!



Mayor Lucas Ramirez



Vice Mayor Alison Hicks

Membership Report

By IdaRose Sylvester
Membership Committee Chair

Members, thank you for your membership in 2021! We appreciate all of you. Last year, we were able to put on some great virtual programs and test an in-person walking tour, and look forward to a mix of virtual and in-person programming in 2022. This programming, our newsletter, and maintaining the organization itself require the support of members like you!

In January, our board voted to adjust membership dues for the first time in many years. These adjusted dues will help our organization keep pace with rising costs, such as printing and mailing, our Zoom subscription, and insurance premiums. We benchmarked our rates with other local historical associations, and our dues will remain some of the most affordable in the region.

Annual memberships now cover entire households, at a rate of $30 per year. Individual Lifetime Memberships are now $300. We hope these changes do not create any financial hardship for any of our loyal, longtime members. If they do, please contact me for a sponsored or subsidized household membership.

As a reminder, we've moved to a January renewal for all annual members. Your renewed membership is valid from January to December 2022. We are almost done updating our website and payment platform to make this process easier for all of you to use. Note that anyone who paid for their membership from September 2021 onward is covered through December 2022!

We'll be sending out renewal notices very soon, but if you know you haven't paid your membership since September 2021, you can use the form below to mail in your renewal, or you can renew and pay online at https://mountainviewhistorical.org/memberships/. Questions? Email IdaRose Sylvester, Membership Chair, at idarose@mountainviewhistorical.org.

Membership as of October 6, 2021*

Honored Members	1
Life Members	108
Family Members	74
Single Members	77
TOTAL MEMBERSHIP	**260**

**Membership roster update in progress! We'll have updated membership numbers in our next newsletter.*

MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! By becoming a member, you are making a special investment in our mission to preserve and share Mountain View history with the community, conserve priceless archival materials at the History Center, and hold memorable public events throughout the year. You can also join and renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Membership is tax deductible to the extent permitted by law. The MVHA is a tax-exempt organization under Internal Revenue Code Section 501(c)(3), Tax ID 94-6115407.
Please support the MVHA, and join us today!

- ☐ New Membership
- ☐ Membership Renewal
- ☐ Household Annual Membership *$30/year*
- ☐ Individual Lifetime Membership *$300*
- ☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

Name(s): _____

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Please make checks payable to:
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Mail this form to:
Mountain View Historical Association
c/o IdaRose Sylvester
P.O. Box 252
Mtn. View, CA 94042

Thank you!

WINTER/SPRING

February 20
Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
MVHA Winter Event
Zoom Webinar
More information on page 11!

February 27
Sunday, 1:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m.
Downtown Walking Tours
Centennial Plaza, 600 W. Evelyn Ave, Mtn. View
Details at: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

March 9
Wednesday, 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.
MVHA Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members are welcome to attend!
Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for login.

May 1
Sunday, Time TBD
MVHA Spring Event & Meeting
Location TBD
More information in our spring newsletter!

Looking Back: Photos from the Archive



This photo comes from our clipping files and appeared in the February 20, 1970, edition of the *San Jose Mercury News*. The accompanying caption stated:

> *Horseback Guess—Mayor William Jelavich of Mountain View (left) and his recreation director, Don Gale, saddled up Thursday and led an entourage of City Councilmen and officials on an inspection tour of the proposed Stevens Creek "do-it-yourself" park chain. The councilmen will authorize tree planting by service clubs and Gale estimated improvements would begin next month.*

Mountain View's efforts were labeled "do-it-yourself" after County officials abandoned plans to build a County Park along the entire course of Stevens Creek, from bay to mountains. Land purchased by the County for the park chain along the route of the Stevens Creek Freeway (Highway 85) was sold to the City in 1967, and City leaders began encouraging local civic groups to plant trees along the creek. Learn more about the history of Stevens Creek at our February 20 webinar!

EST. 1954
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
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Mountain View, CA 94042
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